

WELCOMING ALL EROTIC PARTS OUR REACTIONS TO THE SEXUAL AND USING POLARITIES TO ENHANCE EROTIC EXCITEMENT

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INTRODUCTION

The erotic—the myriad carnal, romantic and transcendent ways to experience sexual desire, fantasy, connection, excitement and fulfillment—is core to being human yet too often receives short shrift in psychotherapy discourse. Sexuality, arguably more than any other domain of life, stirs strong reactions ranging from supreme ecstasy to curious wonder to anxiety, shame, horror, disgust, rage, denial, pathologizing and punishment. This chapter is an invitation to welcome erotic parts—ours and our clients’—along with the parts who are activated in reaction to the erotic.

A case consultation will illustrate working with a clinician’s judgmental parts who were triggered when hearing about the particular sexual pleasures of her clients. The chapter goes on to explore other kinds of parts who are typically reactive to the erotic: those whose beliefs are so blended with cultural messages that they are barely detectable, those who manage emotional reactions through inhibitions and addictions and those who are caught up in erotically charged attraction to clients.

The lens of polarities is a valuable perspective for exploring the highly diverse and idiosyncratic expressions of the erotic. Parts who are seemingly in opposition create tension that can be distressing but can also, paradoxically, be a source of excitement and delight. The standard internal family systems (IFS) approach to polarities involves healing the wounds of exiles whose pain motivates polarized protectors. This chapter posits an alternate view that the dialectical tension of some polarities is inherent

and essential to human nature so that one cannot exist without the other, as with differentiation and integration. From this perspective, the erotic can be understood as a balance of opposing yet complementary forces or energies, such as receptive versus penetrative. In contrast to addressing deeper wounds, this outlook focuses on acceptance (“all polarities are welcome”) and finding equilibrium between polarized desires and prohibitions. Although counterintuitive to managerial parts, our negative reactions to the erotic (e.g., shame, disconnection, guilt or danger) sometimes intensify sexual excitement when we experiment with polarities that involve regulating distance, violating prohibitions and playing with power. Finally, the common struggle between lusty and romantic desires is illustrated in a case vignette at the end of the chapter.

CASE CONSULTATION: A THERAPIST'S REACTIONS TO HER CLIENTS' EROTIC LIFE

Corrine, a senior, well-respected IFS therapist, sought a consultation with me because she felt uncertain about how to proceed with a new couple in therapy. She had seen Marjorie and Don three times. They were in their mid-thirties, white, married for six years, and had a four-year old daughter whom Marjorie cared for at home. Their comfortable, middle-class stability had recently been shaken when the company where Don had worked for several years was sold and his position and salary were reduced. Don felt frustrated, powerless to seek another job during a recessive economy, and guilty that he was no longer a sufficient provider for his family. Marjorie was very disappointed because their plans for having a second child were now jeopardized. Under this stress, they were arguing almost nightly and their usual pleasure from their relationship was fraying. The tipping point came when Marjorie threw a cup, which just missed Don and smashed against the wall. This very uncharacteristic action frightened them both. They decided to seek therapy.

Corrine was a confident couple therapist who felt within two sessions that she had a grasp of their relational problems and the fundamental strength of their loving marriage, as well as their historical vulnerabilities. But in the third session the couple began to talk about the deleterious effect arguing was having on their sex life, which had always been lively and fulfilling. They wanted to use therapy to help rekindle their erotic spark. Corrine, who acknowledged to me with some embarrassment that she does not usually get much information about her clients' sex lives, tentatively asked them to say more. She described how they smiled nervously at one another before Marjorie disclosed that they regularly incorporated pornography into their sexual activities. In particular, both were turned on by scenes of men dominating women, such as a woman being handcuffed to a bed while a man penetrated her, and they delighted in enacting these scenes.

They had been consensually and safely playing out a variety of similar power-themed scenarios for years; this shared desire had always been central to their mutual attraction. Marjorie said that she had masturbated to these semiviolent fantasies since puberty. Don shamefully added that since his job demotion, he could not maintain an erection or his role as the “top” or dominant partner to “humiliate”

Marjorie. And Marjorie was extremely frustrated at Don's losing his willpower to subordinate and "take" her. She admitted to Corrine that this upset her more than their financial stress. In fact, Marjorie had felt her anger building along with the bodily agitation that comes from ungratified sexual yearning and had thrown the cup.

As Corrine described their bedroom preferences during our consultation, she struggled to get the words out. She was flustered and uncertain about whether she could work with this couple. Not only was talking about sexuality in general somewhat uncomfortable for her, but she was shocked to hear about the specific nature of their erotic passion. The idea of women being hurt as a source of sexual arousal was abhorrent to her feminist and ethical principles. She thought that using pornography was the sign of a problem. She speculated whether Marjorie and/or Don were replaying hurts from unresolved trauma, although nothing in their histories indicated abuse. She wondered about the effects of such behavior on raising a child.

Yet, Corrine was also aware that neither Marjorie nor Don had expressed any concerns or misgivings about their sadomasochistic erotic play. No one seemed to be actually getting hurt, both clearly wanted this pleasure back in their lives, and both appeared to be caring and responsible parents to their daughter. She hoped that she had effectively hidden her reactions from the couple and felt both relief and worry when they scheduled another session. Anxious and judging parts within her wanted them to go away while intrepid and intrigued parts wanted to persevere. To her credit, the contradiction between her strongly negative reactions and her perception of their contentment made her puzzled and receptive to learning more—about herself and about the erotic.

When she finished speaking, I invited Corrine to get to know the parts of her who were reacting to this couple's sex life. Corrine had worked with me before and was comfortable using IFS for personal exploration of countertransference. I guided her to go inside, open space for any feelings, parts or sensations and notice what wanted her attention.

She observed, "The loudest part is against people being hurt and women being used by men for their selfish needs. This part was startled and somewhat disgusted and wanted to shout at Don and especially at Marjorie to stop that abusive behavior."

I asked whether this part's attitude made sense to her. She nodded vigorously. "How do you feel toward this part?" I asked.

Corrine said, "I admire and value her. She's been my moral compass for most of my life." She added that this part had become fully formed during her twenties in the women's liberation movement, although her core beliefs had developed earlier.

I said, "I, too, have a part who strongly shares your part's principles. I know that sometimes my part can be so certain that it blends with me so I will take action, sometimes stridently. It's often right. But when it relaxes I can see a broader perspective. I wonder whether your part is blended with you now?"

Corrine paused, "Yes."

I asked, "Would this part be willing to separate a little bit and give you some space?"

Corrine said, "A little."

I suggested, "Thank her for softening. Let her know that she can remain nearby and jump back into our conversation if she gets concerned." Then I asked Corrine, "Please ask your part what she is afraid would happen if she were not so active with regard to your therapy with Marjorie and Don."

Corrine hesitated in a moment of confusion, “At first, the part was going to say that Marjorie will get hurt. But, from what Marjorie said, she wasn’t getting hurt. She said that she really enjoyed being tied up and told to serve Don. I don’t get it. It still creeps me out. But, they say that’s what they want.”

Corrine now had space for a part who was polarized with the first, judging protector. This second part was trying to be phenomenologically present with Marjorie and Don, meeting them where they were rather than imposing judgments on them. I asked Corrine whether she recognized this other part, which was holding considerable Self-energy. She did and very much appreciated its contribution to making her a well-attuned therapist. With this second part, Corrine was in touch with some curiosity about Marjorie and Don’s sexuality and how aggression and violence can become eroticized. She was surprised that once her anxious, judging part relaxed, she was considering a new perspective on basic drives and behaviors.

However, her curiosity stirred a third part who realized that Corrine was not well-educated about sexuality, that she was unclear how to take a sexual history or even how to talk with clients about sexual matters—to use clinical jargon or colloquial slang words. She felt embarrassed toward this prudish part, identifying it as an important gap in her clinical knowledge and in her ease as a therapist. She reflected that she had unconsciously veered conversations away from sexual material in her therapies with other clients. As I guided her to get to know this part, she was surprised. She had assumed that as a feminist she would be comfortable about sexuality, especially the full range of female sexuality. Corrine realized that her involvement in the women’s movement had always been political: she had advocated for women’s socioeconomic equality, even for women’s rights over their bodies, such as legalized abortion, but saw now that she had been naively blind to sexuality.

This part reminded her that the subject of sex was ignored in her parents’ home, that her parents rarely touched in front of others and that sex was almost never mentioned. She saw that a cloud of shameful secrecy had hovered over sexuality in her childhood, and that she had carried this cloud into her adult, conventional sex life. Corrine brought compassion to this young part who had grown up confused and untaught about the diversity and complexity of erotic arousal. With Self-energy, Corrine helped this young part to let go of (unburden) some shame and denial and invite in their place curiosity and openness to learning more about sexuality as well as her own reactions to the erotic.

I asked Corrine whether she would like to try an exercise to notice what parts come forward in reaction to sexual language. Initially hesitant, after some discussion, her reluctant, embarrassed parts softened and she agreed. I explained that I would say a sexual word and her task was to repeat it aloud, sit with it and notice any feelings, associations or reactions. Then we would gently work with those parts and help them relax so she could be present with Self-calm until she was ready to proceed to the next word. (You, the reader, may want to follow along and notice your associations and parts.) I started with *intercourse*. She repeated *intercourse* and described her feelings, thoughts, body sensations or images. As her mildly anxious parts relaxed and more curiosity arrived, we continued on with a few of the following words: *clitoris ... tits ... cock ... jerking off ... transgender ... orgy ... going down ... vulva ... pregnant ... same-sex marriage ... menstruation ... swinging ... fist fucking ... kissing ...*

sadomasochism ... affairs ... sucking ... polyamory ... love. I explained the meanings of unfamiliar terms, such as *fist fucking*, in which one person inserts his or her fist and arm into the other's person's well-lubricated and receptive anal cavity, which, for some people, is highly stimulating.

Corrine noticed that slang words, especially those describing nonmain-stream behaviors, stirred anxious, confused or disgusted reactions. These diminished as her initial response of startle at hearing unfamiliar sexual words became desensitized. She also noticed that a few of the words, such as *kissing*, stirred some mild excitement and slight genital arousal. Although some parts enjoyed these sensations, others were unnerved to feel them while sitting with me in my office. Corrine was discovering the varied, contradictory feelings stirred by sexual and erotic thoughts. She breathed a sigh of relief at the end of this exercise. She said that it was challenging, eye opening and offered her trailheads for further introspection.

At the end of the consultation, we reviewed goals for the couple therapy with Marjorie and Don. Corrine began with a goal for herself: to work with relaxing her judging and anxious parts before her sessions with them so that she could be in Self as much as possible and be welcoming of their erotic parts. She also planned to read an excellent book, *The Erotic Mind* by Jack Morin (1995). I suggested two other resources for further education: courses offered by the American Association of Sex Educators, Counselors, and Therapists (AASECT) and Dan Savage's frank sex advice column, "Savage Love." Corrine intended to begin the next couple session by asking Don and Marjorie what it had been like for them to tell her about their sex life and problems. And, depending on their reactions, Corrine thought she might speak for some of her parts, explaining that much of what they had described was new to her and that she aimed to learn with them as well as on her own (just as a therapist taking a multicultural perspective might express unfamiliarity with and interest in clients' different cultural beliefs and behaviors). She planned to listen carefully to how they talked about their sexual relationship and not to frame their erotic activity as pathological or requiring change unless Marjorie or Don expressed a concern.

In addition to tracking the sequences of their communications (Herbine-Blank, this volume), we discussed helping Don to work with his shaming, blaming, emasculating parts to foster his power and virility, while acknowledging his very real job and financial stressors. Based on his history, we hypothesized that his disempowerment was protecting hurt, young parts who could be unburdened. Similarly, Marjorie could help her disappointed and angry parts who appeared to be rooted in earlier developmental injuries about broken expectations. Corrine recognized that the overarching goal was to help them both return to and strengthen the former satisfactions of their relationship, particularly their sex life, while bringing compassion, calm and creativity to the parts who were frustrated with their current financial limits. We agreed that she would follow up with me as the therapy with Marjorie and Don unfolded.

REACTIONS TO THE EROTIC ARE BLENDED WITH CULTURAL MESSAGES

The consultation with Corrine illustrates that therapists are as susceptible as anyone to viewing sexual behavior and erotic arousal through the lens of familial and cultural conditioning. Many therapists do not receive comprehensive education about the diversity and complexity of human sexuality. They rely on informal social knowledge, personal exposures to sexuality and prejudiced psychiatric models to form their beliefs about what constitutes “healthy” versus “abnormal” sexual motivations and behavior. In the United States, where the dominant culture is polarized between sex-obsession and sex-phobia, we receive messages that vacillate between the extremes of hedonistic libertinism (*gratify yourself ;sex sells ; boys will be boys ;anything goes ;if you’re sexual, you’re popular*) and restrictive Puritanism (*you’ll get ... hurt, diseased, pregnant, ostracized ;it’s sick, sinful, deviant, illegal ;if you’re sexual, you’re a slut*). The culture invokes shame and guilt as well as physical restraint and violence to control people’s sexual urges and to define what specific sexual desires and actions are judged to be right or wrong, blessed or damned (Rubin, 1984). The Biblical creation story can be seen as conveying the Judeo-Christian bottom line about sexual vitality: when the innocent young parts of Adam and Eve are curious to know the erotic Tree of Life, God banishes them from the Garden of Eden, where Self-energy resides, and they enter exile in self-conscious shame about their bodies. This could be the template for Corrine’s story.

There are many topics that can trigger therapists’ parts and prevent bringing nonjudgmental curiosity to their clients’ erotic lives. In talking with therapists about sexuality over the years, these topics include: erotic fantasies, discrepant sexual desire between partners, sexual dysfunctions, pornography, extrarelational affairs, lesbian/gay/bisexual/transgender/queer concerns, gender transitions, polyamory, norms in sexual subcultures, fetishes for arousal, conflicts between religious values and sexual identity, clients who are sex workers, eroticized power and violence, out-of-control and addictive sexual behavior and the effects of sexual trauma on the development of erotic orientation. When faced with the unfamiliar and the unconventional, parts come forward to help with the anxiety of not knowing by creating a story of what must be happening, by assigning labels of good and bad. Corrine began formulating a story that Marjorie and Don’s sadomasochistic sex must be an enactment of past abuse. Along with the narrative, other parts may react with disgust, fear, anger or blaming (pathologizing). These parts may blend so transparently and convincingly that we are sometimes unaware of how our story is interfering with truly getting to know clients’ erotic parts and their parts who judge or shame their erotic parts. This is especially probable when our story matches the outlooks put forth by the larger mental health and sociopolitical systems so our parts have no reason to step back and consider a different perspective.

When a therapist is not in Self, other parts take over. These may be avoidant parts who do not raise and follow up on sexual questions for fear that they will make the client—or the therapist—anxious. They might be relieved to ally with parts of the client who are embarrassed or hesitant to talk about

private sexual subjects. Or, therapist parts could be excessively curious and intrusive, attending to clients' erotic activities for personal titillation or anthropological fascination. If the therapist is the recipient of the client's erotic attention, a variety of conflicting parts could get activated, ranging from squirmy discomfort and genuine fear to narcissistic pleasure and arousal. As with any IFS intervention, the fundamental step is for the therapist to ask him or herself, "How am I feeling toward my client's erotic parts?" If the answer points to reactions that are not qualities of Self, the therapist should explore these reactive parts through introspection or consultation to bring Self-energy to the therapeutic work.

PARTS DEVELOP EXTREME ROLES TO MANAGE OUR REACTIONS TO EROTIC DESIRES

In addition to our reactions to our clients' erotic expressions, people develop parts to manage their reactions to their own erotic feelings. These protector parts fear losing control over erotic impulses, being attacked or abused by others or feeling vulnerable and ashamed. They take over either by inhibiting our sexual desire and behavior and/or by compulsively addicting us to sex. Inhibiting protectors raise anxiety, impose judgments, numb desire, dissociate the body from the mind, interfere with attention or block the functioning of genital parts in the sexual moment (i.e., males not able to get or sustain erections, ejaculating too quickly or not reaching orgasm; females not lubricating, feeling pain, having involuntary vaginal contractions or not reaching orgasm). Addicting protectors compel a person to follow a ritualized repetitive sequence of thoughts and actions for arousal and gratification without regard for harmful consequences, to rapidly alter sensation (provide a "high" or a "fix"), distract from distressing emotions or use sexual contact as a conduit or substitute for tentative intimacy. A person's inner system may be governed primarily by one type of protector or a combination of both. These protectors can operate in the shadows and are frequently polarized against each other, such as a judging inhibiting part who tries to restrict the acting out behavior of an addicting part, who spends hours cruising the Internet for hot masturbatory images. If unsuccessful, the inhibitor dishes out self-loathing and a hangover following the behavior (Wonder, this volume).

THERAPISTS' ATTRACTIONS TO CLIENTS

Another arena potentially rife with challenge is the therapist with erotic feelings for his or her client. Although this was not the case in Corrine's couple therapy, I would like to address some of the parts who are present when it does occur. Although the incidence of actual therapist–client sexual behavior is low, it is common for a therapist's erotic parts to get stimulated in response to some clients. Yet, frank discussion of this subject remains fairly taboo (Bridges, 1998; Pope, Keith-Spiegel, & Tabachnick, 1986). Judging parts, who know of the ethical and legal prohibitions against therapist–client sexual contact, can stir dread, blame, shame and guilt. These critical parts can be powerful enough to prevent therapists

from recognizing and addressing the attraction, which puts them at risk of acting on the feelings (Pope, Sonne, & Holroyd, 1993). Parts serving as clues that a therapist has unacknowledged attraction to a client are listed in Table 11.1.

Table 11.1 Clues That a Therapist Has Not Acknowledged His/Her Erotic Attraction to a Client

- The therapist feels physical tension or nervousness while with or thinks about the client.
- The therapist feels annoyance or frustration with the client for no apparent reason.
- The therapist talks in a neutral or dehumanized manner.
- The therapist views the client as a diagnostic label rather than as a person.
- The therapist misses or cancels sessions to avoid the client.
- The therapist thinks obsessively about the client's treatment.
- The therapist thinks about the client during sex with his or her partner.
- The therapist gives the client undue special treatment.

Drawn from Bridges (1998) and Pope, Sonne, and Holroyd (1993).

Once aware of having sexual feelings for a client, the therapist can be stymied by various strong reactions including shock and surprise, confusion between genuine caring/liking and attraction, anxiety about unresolved personal issues, fear of losing control, fear of being criticized by peers or supervisors, frustration at not being able to speak openly about the feelings or act on them with the client, confusion about boundaries (e.g., “Are these feelings coming from the client or from me?”), anger at the client for eliciting sexual feelings and anxiety about frustrating the flirtatious client's sexual wishes (Pope et al., 1993). The therapist can ask these reactive parts to unblend to hear from the parts who hold the attraction and then work with possible underlying conflicts, such as longings to be loved or admired, a reenactment of an earlier traumatic boundary violation or protection against parts holding other intolerable urges such as rage, sadism or dependency (Bridges, 1998). This process of awareness, acknowledgement and exploration of erotic feelings toward a client requires considerable Self-compassion and courage and often the assistance of a trusted, nonjudgmental peer, supervisor or personal therapist.

CORRINE EXPLORES EROTIC IMAGERY

After three more couple sessions with Marjorie and Don, Corrine returned for a follow-up consultation. She reported that her judging parts had relaxed enough for her to focus on the couple's communication patterns and each partner's internal work. She added that our consultation had stirred her curiosity, and she asked for help with more self-discovery. I guided Corrine through the following imagery exercise, reminding her parts that they were welcome to participate to whatever degree they wanted and that it was fine for her to keep her experience to herself and not describe the imagery aloud.

“Let yourself be comfortable in the chair. Take some slow breaths in and let them out slowly. As you do, open up space inside, bringing your Self-energy and open curiosity. Welcome into this space one of the ways that you experience the erotic. This may be a memory of a past sexual experience, a fantasy, sensations, an image of people or things or a situation. This may or may not be explicitly sexual. If various ways are showing up, try to focus on one, asking the others to relax back. Notice the particular features that make this erotic or sexually exciting for you. What are the main ingredients and what may be hidden in the wings? Notice what you are feeling and thinking in reaction to being with this erotic experience. Maybe you sense some genital stirrings or other bodily signs of arousal. Do you feel fully absorbed? Or, are parts watching how this experience is going for you?”

At the outset, Corrine was aware of feeling self-conscious, which she noticed in tightness around her chest and midsection. She spoke for a judging part who was wary of her focusing on anything erotic, especially in my presence.

I assured her, “I am not holding any judgment and I’m welcoming whatever you experience. Ask the judging ones to let you know about their concerns and see if they make sense to you. Then, ask them to soften back and let you be as fully present as possible with your erotic experience.”

Corrine’s body visibly relaxed and she was quiet for a couple of minutes. Then, with a light smile, Corrine opened her eyes, “I’ve never really done that before—just be with some sexual thoughts and feelings, especially with someone else in the room. I felt nervous but it was also nice. I was thinking about a time during a vacation with my husband. We had gone sailing with another couple. It was a beautiful day and I remember being on the boat and looking at Mark and thinking he was still handsome. I felt a little turned on, with the sun, the gentle movement of the boat in the water. This feeling stayed with me during dinner with our friends. Then Mark and I went back to our hotel room. Maybe he had been feeling it too because we just started kissing and ended up making love slowly but with more passion than usual. Even now, as I remember that day, I feel some excitement.”

I asked Corrine, “How do you feel as you tell me this?”

Corrine said, “A little embarrassed but OK.” She paused. “But,” a worried part who was slightly blended with Corrine wanted to know, “is it OK?”

I said, “It is OK and you can ask the worried part what it’s concerned about.”

She listened to its concern about revealing this private memory and it softened.

I asked whether she would like to learn more about the erotic, from my didactic part who likes to teach about sexuality. She was interested and her curious, learning parts perked up.

CONSIDERING THE EROTIC FROM THE PERSPECTIVE OF POLARITIES

We usually think of the erotic as that which we think, feel and do to stimulate and heighten sexual and intimacy desires, arousal and orgasm. The cliché that the brain is our most erogenous organ is true; we filter all the sensory moments of the body through the meanings, fantasies and scripts we create, based

on genetic predispositions, personal experiences and culturally constructed standards (Leitenberg & Henning, 1995; Mosher, 1980; Stoller, 1979). The erotic encompasses a huge range, including sensation, imagery, emotional intimacy, tantric and spiritual realms that extend beyond rationality and logic (Collins, 1993; Muir & Muir, 1989; Steinberg, 1992). The concept of polarities offers a broader perspective to understand and enhance erotic experience. After first explaining how polarities are used in IFS, I extend this concept and apply it to the erotic.

THE IFS PERSPECTIVE ON POLARITIES

According to IFS theory, parts develop polarized relationships in response to developmental wounds and traumas (Schwartz, 1995). For example, a client, Rose, held intense shame about her body due to her parents' having punished her as a child for touching (and enjoying touching) her genitals. To cope with her mortification, one of her protector parts took on an obedient role in which she ignored her body and suppressed her erotic experimentation to try to win her parents' attention and love, while another protector became angrily defiant and developed a secretly promiscuous sex life with men and women but always faked orgasms. Although Rose appeared to win approval for being a "nice girl," her flirty, provocative part always waited in the wings to take over. As a result of this polarized conflict, she had veered into dangerous, life-threatening encounters.

"My flirty part hates that nice girl. Really hates her," Rose reported early on.

By following the standard IFS treatment toward polarities I helped Rose bring curiosity, calm and compassion to facilitate communication between these parts so that over time their relationship changed to be less embattled.

"They can see that they were both trying to protect me. The flirty one wanted to say 'Fuck you!' to my parents. 'How dare you!' While the nice girl wanted to capture their love."

Through a lengthy process of establishing a trusting relationship between her Self and these wounded protectors, Rose got access to the underlying hurt, the shamed little girl, and helped her to unburden shameful beliefs about her body and her own desire to explore it. This helped the furious flirty part and took the steam out of its polarity with the nice girl. Both of these protectors eventually became cooperative advisors, allowing Rose to practice sensual self-touching exercises so she could experience orgasm and realize greater stability in her life.

POLARITIES AS ESSENTIAL DIALECTICAL TENSIONS

However, there is a kind of polarity that emerges from life's essential dialectical tensions rather than from wounds. One universal polarity, both for individuals and societies, is security versus freedom: as we seek greater security, we feel safer but live with stronger controls and reduced liberties. In contrast,

as we seek greater freedom, we may do more of what we want but risk conflict, danger and insecurity. Another basic polarity is autonomy versus dependency or being separate versus being connected. Every person in a relationship grapples with achieving the best balance between these opposing needs. IFS itself is founded on the polarity that differentiation (of parts from Self and from each other) is necessary for assimilation (into a whole harmonious system of balanced multiple parts). Each of these polarities is a paradox: although some of our parts gravitate toward one side, we cannot live without the other. We all face the inherent push–pull of these seemingly contradictory forces. Although there may be early hurts associated with these essential tensions, the goal here is less toward unburdening and more toward accepting the natural and inevitable nature of these opposite pulls. Rather than suffering from the clash of polarized parts, we can use Self-energy to appreciate and play with them to find our own Self-led equilibrium. All polarities are welcome!

THE EROTIC AS ESSENTIAL POLARITIES

As with other polarities, the erotic is a composite of complementary polar forces or energies essential in sexuality and in life. In western thought, this is the interplay of eros (loving, unifying, and life creating and sustaining energies) and Thanatos (aggressive, differentiating and life destroying and ending energies; Freud, 1920/[1961](#)). In Chinese philosophy, this polarity is the balance between the forces of yin (earth, soft, female, dark, passive and absorbing) and yang (heaven, hard, male, light, active and penetrating; *New Encyclopedia Britannica*, 1997). These competing principles exist within all of us to varying degrees. The particular give-and-take tensions between these forces result in the idiosyncratic ways in which each of us experience not only sexual desire and excitement but everyday events as diverse as watching a sunset or handling a business transaction. Virtually every polarized dimension of life has been a source for stimulation and passion, such as the animate to the inanimate, the whole person to objectified body parts, private to public, harmonious to torture, magic to realism, safe to dangerous, pleasure to pain, freedom to slavery, the sacred to the profane, and the known to the unknown. As with the other universal polarities, the goal is to be aware of the competing erotic forces from an outlook of curiosity, courage and compassion to experiment and find the best balance.

POLARITIES FUEL EROTIC EXCITEMENT FOR INDIVIDUALS AND COUPLES

A paradox of polarities is that although protective parts aim to reduce the distress arising from strong reactions to sexual desires, the push–pull antagonism among these parts can enhance sexual excitement. Protectors relegate erotic wishes, ranging from silly and ridiculous to dark and dangerous, or spacious and transcendent, to the shadows of the “inappropriate,” “undesirable” or “unknown.” When our Self is genuinely curious about the parts who hold ashamed, anxious, guilty, angry, inhibiting or addicting

reactions, we can ask them what they fear would happen if they were not doing their protective jobs. The answer often directs us to concerns about losing control, being bad, getting punished or hurt or feeling alone and abandoned. Although we can use IFS to heal these basic vulnerabilities, we can also experiment with these seemingly undesirable reactions to provoke erotic tension. A modicum of anxiety, guilt, embarrassment, disappointment, anger, pressure and even pain goes a long way to escalating sexual passion (Morin, 1996). As one client realized, “Doing what is shameful is exciting.” But if our parts (or our partner’s parts) push us too far, then we are turned-off, overwhelmed by a backlash of fear, shame, disgust or too much pain, and can feel traumatized. The optimal balance between eros and Thanatos or yin–yang energies varies widely across situations and among people. A scenario or erotic style that exhilarates one person completely shuts down another. Experimenting with the polarized concerns of our protector parts from a Self-led perspective allows us to discover our most exciting paths to erotic delight.

Although playing with polarities promotes growth as individual sexual beings, when two (or more) persons bring Self-energy for imaginative investigation together, they have the power to create enthralling sexual pleasure. In long-standing domestic relationships, passionate parts are often exiled due to some parts’ fear that sexual desire will destroy attachment (McCarthy & McCarthy, 2009; Morin, 1996; Perel, 2006; Schnarch, 1997). In IFS, we ask our parts to “step back” to make space for their relationship with our Self; we need to be separate to be together. Differentiation is essential for healthy attachment (Herbine-Blank, this volume; Schnarch, 1997; Schwartz, 2008). Working with the polarities within us and between our parts and our partner’s parts facilitates differentiation. If two partners are very similar in their sexual tastes and styles, they may enjoy a pleasant and comfortable sexual connection but the repetitive familiarity may jeopardize their early zest, attraction and sexual desire. An erotic charge can be maintained when each partner brings a somewhat different and independent set of desires, fantasies and tastes and is open to changing an established pattern. When our anxious parts relax enough to trust ourselves and our partner(s) and we can approach sexuality with Self-leadership, we establish the safety necessary to be aware of what we want—and don’t want—and to communicate these to our partner(s). For example, a person with shy and reserved parts, who plays with being seen by showing off his or her exhibitionistic parts in front of a partner, brings a new equilibrium to his or her inner system, fresh erotic treats to their relationship, and prompts the partner to explore new styles (Queen, 1995). The shared investigation of hidden wishes enriches a couple’s sex life, while the trust required in taking risks without fear of being judged deepens their emotional intimacy.

Let’s look at three common polarities, each of which relies on approach– avoidance tension for a couple’s sexual delectation: creating longing through distance between partners, violating prohibitions and playing with power through dominance and submission (Morin, 1996). The first involves physical or emotional separation between partners that stirs yearning and excited anticipation of being together. Although being close seems like the natural position between partners, too much closeness can feel claustrophobic and prevent knowing one’s own erotic wants and limits. This feeling of enmeshment kindles protective impulses to withdraw or to push a partner away through a fight. In a good relationship, actual distance such as when a partner is away on travel, and emotional distance, perhaps caused by a temporary argument, exacerbate the urge to reconnect and be in one another’s arms. Corrine’s memory of the building erotic tension between her and her husband on their sailing vacation is an example.

Romantic parts who appreciate the aphrodisiac power of distance might say, “Absence makes the heart grow fonder,” while lusty parts might crow, “Absence makes the cock grow harder.” Partners can build mounting sexual anticipation into their relationship by, for example, undressing each other very slowly during foreplay (Morin, 1996), or by living apart and seeing each other only occasionally. Slowing down the sexual encounter also encourages partners to notice any parts that are interfering with staying present in the moment. When partners limit the stimulation of touch to, say, each other’s pinkie fingers, they can more clearly sense—with some humor—the parts urging closeness and those seeking distance.

For some people, violating prohibitions is an excellent strategy to heat erotic frisson by working polarities involving guilt, shame, and fear. One polarity exploits the tension between innocence (*I am good and I should be good*) and guilt (*I like being naughty or dirty*). Another variation toys with staying safe (*We should follow the rules so no one gets hurt*) versus risking the forbidden (*Let’s break taboos, push boundaries and chance consequences*). Rose had struggled with an extreme version of this polarity. To hazard the dangerous (e.g., unprotected intercourse between strangers), the possibility of being caught (e.g., having sex in public) or an internal backlash (e.g., a shame attack after a provocative sexual encounter) is very compelling for some whereas these anxiety-inducing ingredients restrain others. Fantasy invites us to “release moral, social, and pragmatic constraints” to “push the boundaries further than we would in real life” (Morin, 1996, pp. 90–91). The mysterious power of fantasy resides in simultaneously forgetting the taboos and remembering that we’re violating them (Morin, 1996).

Every sexual encounter involves the negotiation of power. This is implicit and unspoken in many relationships yet is clearly defined by the roles that partners automatically take during sex, such as the traditional missionary position with the man on top and the woman on bottom. When the power dynamics are explicit and considered openly between partners, there is a rich opportunity to use this dimension for fantasy role-play to stir much erotic excitement. This polarity is between dominance (*I want to be in charge and have control*) and submission (*I want to surrender control*). Marjorie and Don embraced this polarity to spark their sex life. Each partner chooses his or her role as a top or a bottom to enact a scene. The partners consent to rules, which are often established by the bottom, about safety, limits on subjugation and pain, desired actions, and use of accouterments such as leather, bondage, or other objects of domination (Morin, 1996). “A forceful partner demonstrates with his or her passion the value and desirability of the one who submits. A submissive partner demonstrates through his or her surrender the irresistible erotic powers of the aggressor” (Morin, 1996, p. 97).

The distinction between playing with power responsibly (e.g., in sadomasochistic role-play) and nonconsensual violation, such as rape or child molestation, is crucial. For many people, including therapists such as Corrine, their protector parts go on high alert when hearing about S and M erotic play. Corrine was able to bring Self-calm and curiosity to this subject and relaxed her part who had assumed that Don and Marjorie’s sex life was necessarily a traumatic re-enactment or proof of past sexual abuse. A careful history will reveal themes of nonconsensual activity and past experiences of being forced or of forcing another. Although being humiliated is a major turn-off for many people (and might be a sign of past abuse), some people, such as Marjorie and Don, find consensual humiliation a turn-on. Playing with power involves the paradox of partners respecting and caring for each other regardless of the overt text of their script.

TENSIONS EMERGING FROM POLARITIES BETWEEN ROMANTIC AND LUSTY PARTS

A challenging polarity is between lusty parts seeking hot sex and relational parts wanting a successful romantic partnership. Everyone faces the question, is there room for erotic passion, fantasy and aggression in an enduring, respectful, caring, intimate and loving relationship? Are all erotic and reactive parts truly welcome? Yours and mine?

Lusty parts seek sex for recreation and the highly reinforcing psychophysiological sensations that come from touching, stimulating erogenous areas and having orgasm. These parts may be testosterone driven and also socially conditioned. Lusty parts objectify the other person (sometimes as a “type”) and focus on particular physical features (e.g., large breasts, a big cock) or a particular manner (e.g., preppy, tough, soft) to stir arousal. *Relational parts* seek sex for emotional attachment, intimacy and romantic love. In contrast to lusty parts, which want Mr. or Ms. Right Now, our relational parts seek Mr. or Ms. Right to form an enduring and loving (monogamous or polyamorous) relationship over time. Relational parts yearn to see and be seen, to feel safe enough to reveal our vulnerabilities and desires and trust that our partner will accept them ([Schnarch, 1997](#)). If our lusty parts are strong but sense that other parts internally or in the partner are not welcoming, then the lust may either recede or seek outlets away from one’s partner.

CASE ILLUSTRATION: JUSTIN'S CONFLICT BETWEEN LUSTY PARTS AND RELATIONAL PARTS

By mid-adulthood, Justin was living with housemates and eking out a living. His occasional brief dating relationships with men began with initial pleasure but faded as he grew disenchanted over waning sexual attraction or incompatible interests. Returning to being single, Justin liked having time for himself and the freedom for on-the-spot sexual hookups yet he felt lonely, sometimes depressed and longed for a steady companion. Justin sought therapy with the hope that he would stop repeating this long-standing ambivalent pattern and sustain a good relationship.

At the outset of treatment, I had to attend to some of my parts. On seeing Justin’s hunky body when we met in the waiting room, my lusty part purred “hmmm” inside. I quickly brought Self-calm to this reaction, which remained inactive and in the wings throughout the therapy. Then, reflecting on the repetition themes in Justin’s story, I relaxed my part who was convinced that entrenched ambivalence cannot be altered. I invited Justin to consider that “All parts are welcome here.” Drawing on the

dialectical principle that trying to change a distressing pattern (or “repetition compulsion”) intensifies the polarity between parts who insist on change (“I’ll never feel happy and be truly alive if I continue to vacillate.”) and parts who maintain the pattern (“Since either partnering or singlehood means psychic death, I choose neither.”), I suggested that Justin accept ambivalence as his home base rather than viewing it as a problem to change. Accepting the pattern undercuts arguing about how to resolve it and, paradoxically, opens the door for change.

Justin was surprised by this idea but receptive. I guided him to gradually invite all of his wishing parts (wishing for solitude, partnered intimacy, erotic fulfillment) and the parts carrying judging or anxious reactions toward the wishing parts to gather around a table with Justin at its head for a “greet and meet.” With my guidance, he told them he wanted to get to know them all and asked them to soften and take turns so he could hear one at a time. He also said that regardless of his decision about being single or partnered, there would always be space for each of them and he would continue to take their wants and fears into consideration. We repeated this round table exercise over a number of sessions. I was persistent in patiently encouraging his system to make room for his Self, and Justin’s parts tentatively began to trust that he wasn’t going to ignore the needs of some while pursuing the desires of others.

During this early phase of therapy, Justin met Mike through a mutual acquaintance. Justin smiled as he described Mike as friendly, warm, thoughtful, with a strong body and a good-sized penis. While they felt an initial mutual chemistry, Justin’s disappointed parts anticipated that his dating involvement with Mike would run its course similar to his previous truncated relationships. Nevertheless, by continuing to relate to these parts and validate their concerns, Justin was remaining in the relationship and began to have tentative hope.

Not surprisingly, in reaction to this deepening connection, Justin’s polarized parts began to feel trapped and they activated his lusty part’s urges to seek sex with other hot men. Fit men with big cocks turned on this lusty part, who also had pushed Justin to work out over the years to develop his own well-built physique. Although this part appreciated Mike’s penis, it worried that Mike’s pleasure in desserts and inconsistent exercise habits would eventually turn Mike’s body to flab and Justin’s attraction would fizzle. Beginning to panic, the lusty part insisted that Justin extricate himself from the relationship pronto, deal with any hurts that his sudden goodbye might cause to Mike and run for freedom. Other parts of Justin despised and derided this lusty part and stirred strong guilt for merely noticing other guys’ bodies. Meanwhile, Justin’s relational parts saw his growing intimacy with Mike as the answer to their yearnings for an enduring love and they sought to exile the lusty part permanently. Justin felt paralyzed as these competing agendas pulled him in opposite directions. His lusty part complained of increasing irritation and boredom with Mike.

Justin also was concerned that I was judging his lusty urges. I said honestly that I wasn’t and asked him to let me know if he perceived anything judgmental in my expression or tone. My goal was to be steady, compassionate to his distress, interested in the push–pull tension of his parts, and welcoming all. I checked inside and found that some of my parts were in the same polarities as Justin’s: some were rooting for his relationship with Mike to succeed whereas others identified with his lusty part and

concluded that he should exit the relationship. While asking my parts to relax and trust Justin's system, I also disclosed my parallel process so that he might feel less alone and could see such parts are able to soften. Justin found my self-revelation reassuring.

"Would you like to get to know your lusty part better?" I asked during the next session.

Although other parts were nervous about the lusty part gaining influence if it were heard, they were also beginning to trust Justin's Self-energy and so they did agree to relax.

"My job," the lusty part said, "is to keep Justin sexually turned on so he will stay lively, young and powerful." It had been working hard to fulfill this mission at least since early puberty. It liked the job but was angry about the scornful treatment it got from other parts.

I guided Justin to ask his lusty part, "What are you afraid would happen if you were not doing this job?"

The part showed Justin a picture of himself as a shriveled, tired old man. This unexpected image made sad sense to Justin as he recalled, with light tears, how often he had felt weak and unmanly as a boy. "I was slightly chubby and I didn't have many friends," Justin said. "When I'm around fit, well-built men where there's some sexual chemistry, I feel strong and more masculine. I can feel a kind of healthy aggressive energy." This was in powerful contrast to the feeling of being inadequate that he had experienced throughout most of his childhood and early adulthood. In his twenties, Justin had begun working out and, as an enviable, desirable body blossomed, he had also developed confidence for the first time.

"I'm so grateful to this part," Justin said near the end of the session. "It saved me." As he said this he could feel the oppositional parts, who had been paying close attention, softening their judgment as well.

At our next session I asked Justin, "Will the lusty part allow you to make direct contact with young Justin, who carries those beliefs about being weak and undesirable?"

After getting permission from Justin's protectors, the young part reminded him of the pain of growing up with erotic attractions to other boys and men and the guilty excitement of his secret, compartmentalized sexual life. As a boy and then a teenager, he had tried to hide his gay orientation from his family, and especially from his domineering, rejecting father, whose love and recognition Justin had desperately sought, although other parts had initially denied this paternal longing. During this and subsequent sessions, Justin witnessed, sometimes calmly and sometimes tearfully, memories of hurtful, invalidating, homophobic experiences that had led parts of him to internalize blaming messages from his family and peers. I guided Justin to accompany this young part in surrendering shameful self-beliefs and then inviting in qualities of manliness, playfulness and self-acceptance.

Appreciating this newly deep relationship between Justin and young Justin, the lusty part felt less driven to insist that Justin be with a man whose body was perfect but was still concerned about being trapped in a committed relationship that could lose its sexual fire. This shift by the lusty part to a less extreme position made room for Justin to explore his relational parts. As he worked with the parts who feared intimacy and underlying aloneness, Justin felt increasingly confident about living together with Mike. After testing the partnering waters for a few months and discovering that he could satisfactorily hold his still ambivalent, polarized parts, Justin decided to end therapy, with the understanding that he was welcome to return in case the lusty part reared its head and pushed Justin to seek sex with other men.

CONCLUSIONS

Can we welcome our erotic, opposing energies along with the parts who have polarized reactions to our desires? Because our protective parts judge, inhibit and compel us with strong emotions, this process is challenging. Yet the distressing states of guilt, fear, anger, shame, powerlessness or pain that we try to avoid can be approached to fuel passion under the right circumstances. Being aware of our attractions and reactions to sexual differences also invites the erotic into therapy with genuine acceptance. When we bring Self-curiosity, compassion, and courage to our protectors as well as our exiles, we discover not only that we can tolerate the desires that pull us in different directions, but also we can accept and play with them to heighten erotic excitement and deepen intimacy. Further, when our protectors feel truly calm and able to trust Self, we can open ourselves to transcendent connection, union and bliss with the erotic.

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